mind.

First, the possibilities in a crisis are the product of previous work that has been done in the early stages of the pipeline, and the human capabilities for stages 5, 6 and 7 that have been built ahead of time. The apparently high marginal product of crisis is partly grounded in misattribution; a lot of the credit has to go to the investments by the policy community of previous years. When we see the correlation between crisis and reforms, we are exaggerating the role of the runner who carries the baton across the finish line.

Investments in the early stages of the policy pipeline, and in human capacity, have to be in place. Otherwise, a crisis will be wasted. As an example, the rape in Delhi on 16 December 2012 created a political moment for reform of the criminal justice system. However, as the early stages of the pipeline had not been constructed ahead of time, and human capabilities for stages 5, 6 and 7 were weak, the response that was obtained in that terrible moment was weak.

The second concern that has to be kept in mind is that when the range of possibilities is enlarged, this includes some very harmful ideas. We should not think that the leadership is always benign and intelligent. Crises are dangerous moments when placed in a fragile liberal democracy like India.

Authoritarian rulers chafe against the checks and balances of a free press, the legislature, the courts and independent statistics. Democratic politics is about the hard work of negotiation, and when it works, heads of state routinely experience defeat. Authoritarian leaders find this a frustrating process; in fact they are often inexperienced in the culture of democratic law-making. They lack the temperament of sharing power, and are uncomfortable with the traditions of criticism and compromise.

Crises offer aspiring authoritarians an escape from constitutional shackles. When security threats arise, it is easy to label all critics as anti-national. When national security is at risk, the press, the courts and opposition parties are more deferential. We have numerous examples of crises that gave damaging outcomes. Hitler exploited the Reichstag fire in 1933. In Peru, an insurgency and economic crisis gave Fujimori the